UNIT 4: STRATEGIES FOR SUCCESS

PART I: JOB READINESS

TOPIC 3: TECHNOLOGY ETIQUETTE IN THE WORKPLACE

Topic OBJECTIVES: The learner will:

- Understand the basics of technology etiquette in the workplace
- Understand the importance of having a professional e-mail address and voicemail message
- Understand the potential risks and benefits of social networking sites

Topic OUTCOMES: The learner will:

- Create a professional e-mail address (if he/she does not already have one)
- Create a professional voicemail message
- Obtain or strengthen knowledge around what to post and how to use social networking sites

Topic ACTIVITIES:

Cell Phone Exercise

Objective: Students will experience the disruptive power of technology in the workplace.
Time: 5 minutes

This is a simple and funny activity/warm-up/icebreaker for large groups.

The exercise especially demonstrates the influential power of mobile phones (and by inference, other communication methods such as e-mails) to disrupt effective working, time management and organizational efficiency.

Normally, groups at conferences and training sessions are asked to switch off their mobile phones/cell phones. Try a different twist: Ask all delegates to **switch on** their phones. Say that this is a demonstration of the disruptive and negative effects of technology controlling people rather than vice-versa.

Ask delegates to select the loudest most annoying message alert tone/ringtone. Ask everyone to text a friend (or two or several friends each) whom they know to be keen in responding to text messages. ***(If it is not safe to ask people to text friends, you could simply ask everyone to turn up their phone as loud as possible and wait to see what happens).***

Then, continue with the training or conference session, and wait for the chaotic interruptions to begin. The chaos is a very audible demonstration of what typically happens in organizations where people are not managing their incoming communications.

When your point is made, you'll need to ask everyone to switch off their phones again.

Discussion questions:

- When/where should people turn their phones off or put them on silent?
- What should you do if you forget to put your phone on silent and it rings out loud?
- What should you do if you need to take a call while you are in a meeting?
- What other cell phone etiquette points should people be aware of?

Points of interest:

- Compulsive checking of e-mails and being continuously available to incoming text messages, etc., is considered by some experts to be driven by the same impulses that are experienced by gamblers, i.e., following the principle of unpredictable occasional reward, and similar descriptions of such behavior.
- Surveys regularly find vast amounts of wasted time spent by workers dealing with e-mails and e-mail interruptions. A 2008 report in the Guardian newspaper staggeringly calculated that a worker who checks/responds to e-mail interruptions every five minutes wastes 8.5 hours a week, given the recovery time required after each interruption.
- Inappropriate use of e-mails prevents people from communicating and resolving issues by phone.
- Inappropriate use of phones/texting prevents people from communicating and resolving issues face to face.

http://www.businessballs.com/freeteambuildingactivities.htm#team-building-games-exercises-activities

Large Group Discussion: Voicemail Messages and E-mail Addresses

Objectives:
- Students will understand the importance of having a professional voicemail message on their cell phone (and home phone).
- Students will create professional voice mail messages.

Time: 15 minutes

Materials: Handout: **"Professional Voicemail Messages,"** pre-recorded professional, unprofessional, and extremely long musical voice mail messages

Pre-record a mix of unprofessional, professional, and extremely long musical voicemail messages on phones that you would be able to call for training purposes; OR if you know your group well enough and you know the messages some of them have on their phones, call some of their phones as examples or professional and/or unprofessional messages, OR you can record messages on a tape recorder or computer to play at the session.

Let students know that it is your job to call potential candidates to schedule interviews. Your supervisor wants you to schedule 5 more interviews before you leave for the day. Your shift ends in 10 minutes. You have a list of 30 potential candidates to call.

You call candidate number one and hear: Play first message. What would you do?
You call candidate number two and hear: Play second message. What would you do?
Continue until you play all of the prepared messages.

What would make you hang up on someone's message and call the next person?
What would convince you to put a star next to a candidate's name on the interview list?
What happens if a number is no longer in service? Would you bother trying to find another number? Why or why not?
What should a professional voicemail message include?

E-mail Addresses

Objectives:
- Students will understand the importance of having a professional e-mail address.
- Students will each create their own professional e-mail address.

Time: 15 minutes

Materials: Computers with Internet access, flipchart, markers

Ask students if they currently have an e-mail address. If they do, ask them to put the first half of their e-mail on the flipchart (everything before the @). If they do not have an e-mail address, or if they are not comfortable sharing their own e-mail, ask them to create an e-mail name and write it on the flipchart (or write one that they have seen). You might want to add some unprofessional names that you have seen or make some up. For example: foxiladi, sexy4eva, bigpimpin508, or thebestueverhad.

Ask students to look at the names on the list. Ask for a volunteer to circle the ones that are professional and/or appropriate to put on a resume or application. Ask why it is important to have a professional e-mail address. Why does it matter what your e-mail address is? What assumptions might people make based on an e-mail address? What first impression are you giving when you send a resume from an unprofessional e-mail address?

Help students who do not have a professional e-mail address (or who do not have an e-mail address at all) sign up for a professional e-mail address. Make sure they write down the address and password somewhere safe.

Reading/Discussion

Objective: Students will think about and discuss the potential risks and benefits of social networking sites.

Time: 20 minutes

Materials: Handout " MySpace vs. Workplace"

Have students read the article **"MySpace vs. Workplace"** as one large group. Ask for students to volunteer to read out loud. Stop at certain points to discuss the article as you read. This will help to keep students engaged and help with their comprehension.

Discussion Questions:

- Should employers look at candidate's MySpace/Facebook pages? Why or Why not?
- What do you think someone could post that an employer would not like?
- If you were an employer, what might you look for on a candidate's page?
- Do you think people should get fired or not get hired for something on their page? What do you think would be serious enough to fire someone? What would be something that could change someone's mind about hiring someone?
- Where is the line between personal and professional on the Internet?

Remind young people once something is posted online or sent through e-mail/text message, it is no longer in the sender's control. You can't always take back a picture, a post, a text — so think about whether or not you want a future employer judging you on a post/picture before you put it on the Internet.

Professional Voicemail Messages

- Hello, you have reached Sam's voicemail, I am not available at the present moment, but if you leave your name, number and a short message, I'll be sure to get back to you as soon as possible.
- Hello, you've reached Nicole. I'm currently not available. Please leave your name and number and I'll make sure to return your call within one business day.
- Hi, you've reached Miguel. I'm sorry that I am not available to answer your call at the present time. Please leave your name, number and a quick message at the tone, and I'll return your call as soon as I can.
- Hi this is Chrystal. I'm either away from my desk or on the phone; please leave your name and number along with a short message, and I'll be sure to get back to you.
- Hello, you have reached the office of Ricardo; I will be out of town starting on Tuesday, October 18th, and will be returning on Monday, October 24th. You can call me when I return, or leave a brief message.
- Hello, you have reached the voicemail of Maria. I am currently unavailable; please leave your name and number and I will be happy to return your call.

Create your own professional voice mail message:

Adapted from http://www.creativevoicemailmessages.com/vm/professional1.htm

MySpace vs. Workplace

During the day you're all business; at night you like to let loose and have some fun. No problem with that — unless you share your adventures with others on the Internet.

By Don Aucoin, Globe Staff I May 29, 2007

At 35, Eva Montibello is not exactly ancient, and she considers herself reasonably Internet-savvy. Still, it never would have occurred to her to scrutinize a MySpace page the way she would, say, a resume.

When she did so, she found it an eye-opening — and eye-widening — experience.

Montibello, the marketing manager at a Newton-based consulting firm, was screening job candidates last year when an application came in from a recent college graduate. As she prepared to set up an interview with the applicant, one of her younger co-workers asked a fateful question: "Did you check out her MySpace page?"

Montibello did so, and there on the applicant's public profile she found what she calls "all kinds of compromising photos," including one of her applicant Jell-O-wrestling. Still, that "wasn't necessarily an issue" to Montibello or her boss. "The real issue came when my boss was interviewing her and mentioned it, and the person was like 'Oh, yeah, it was so funny,' and was so cavalier about it, instead of being responsible," she says.

They ultimately hired someone else. The applicant's blasé reaction to questions about her MySpace photos "wasn't the deal-breaker, but it was a factor," says Montibello. "We had another candidate who was equally qualified, and who showed up at the interview and was professional all the way. When you're comparing two or three people, everything matters."

Like it or not — and many employees emphatically do not — social-networking sites such as MySpace and Facebook are creating an increasingly murky workplace terrain.

What happens in Vegas may stay in Vegas, but what happens on MySpace can make it into the wider world, whether it is office gossip, racy photographs, or first-person accounts of weekend revelry. Conversations — about work, about bosses, about co-workers — that used to take place at water coolers or on barstools now potentially have a much larger audience. With one high-speed collision after another between MySpace and the workplace, the personal and the professional are converging in new and unpredictable ways.

Yet there is no consensus on where the line should be — or even if there should be a line.

"Whatever I do outside or after work shouldn't be brought up against my work review," contends Lydia Fabiano, 23, of Braintree, who has a MySpace page she allows co-workers to see. "Just about every person has their own thing that they do outside of work. As long as it doesn't hinder your work performance, it should be two separate things. Whatever I do at 10 o'clock on a Saturday night shouldn't matter at all to my boss."

However, employers don't necessarily see it that way. The clash between the interests of employers and the private lives of employees has been on vivid display recently.

The Defense Department, citing concerns about too much "recreational traffic" on MySpace and a dozen other websites, announced that it was cutting off access to the sites by military personnel. A supervisor in an Olive Garden restaurant in Florida was fired after she posted photos or herself, her daughter, and other restaurant employees hoisting empty beer bottles. (The restaurant contended the photos could damage the company's brand). A university in Pennsylvania, contending she had promoted underage drinking, denied a 27-year-old woman a teaching degree just before graduation after she posted a photo of herself that was titled "Drunken Pirate."

She filed a lawsuit against the university, but Harvey Schwartz, a Boston attorney who specializes in civil rights and employment discrimination, says that in general, he doesn't think sites like MySpace will be considered private from a legal standpoint. "I don't really see it as much of a legal issue," says Schwartz, of Rodgers, Powers & Schwartz. "If you're putting something up on the Internet, anybody can read it. I don't think you should complain if somebody reads it who you hadn't planned on reading it.

"This is something that people are going to be learning. It's a new area," he adds. "It's just like when e-mail first happened. People were wild and crazy with what they said on e-mails, and it came back to bite them. People are going to learn the same thing about MySpace."

On the most basic level, employers worry about lost productivity. Lynda Slevoski, vice president of Associated Industries of Massachusetts, says she hears increasing complaints from employers about employees dawdling on MySpace during company time. "Because you can do so many things on MySpace — you can get e-mail, you can do chat groups, you can have a virtual baby shower — there are more ways for an employee to be sidetracked at work to do all this stuff," Slevoski says. "At some companies, people are spending more than half their time on MySpace, as opposed to working. And they're utilizing company equipment."

Employees, meanwhile, have their own set of concerns. Some wonder whether employers are using MySpace profiles to violate the privacy of employees or applicants and obtain personal information to which they are not entitled. Warren Agin, a Boston attorney who specializes in Internet law, says employers would run afoul of antidiscrimination laws if they use a MySpace page to learn, say, that a job applicant is gay, and decide not to hire him or her on that basis.

"There are many aspects of MySpace profiles that are not legal on job applications," notes Jody Kordana, an administrative assistant at Pittsfield Community Television. "Say a woman goes for a job interview, and she passes the standard recruitment process, and someone goes to her MySpace page and discovers she's a single mother or she had stated something about her difficulties in finding good child care." That, Kordana says, could lead some employers to unfairly conclude "she might not be reliable."

"MySpace is a social site. The whole idea is to make some friends, or to have old friends find you, on a social level," says Kordana, 34, who also works as an actress. "And we should be completely free to do that. But on a professional level, we're having to censor ourselves from potential future employers. How much control do we want the companies to have over our private lives? If you are proving yourself in the workplace and you are not putting the image of your employer at risk, I feel that your private life is yours."

While the issue sorts itself out, there will continue to be episodes that illustrate how MySpace has complicated the relationship not just between employers and employees, but among employees as well.

Take the case of Dana Schaeffer of Burlington. When she started a new job a year ago, Schaeffer, now 42, required training from two co-workers who were in their 20s. At home one night about two weeks after she started the job, she was on her own MySpace page when, she recalls, she thought to herself: "Hmm, I wonder if anybody in my office has it. They seem like a pretty techno-savvy place." So she typed in the name of one co-worker, checked out his MySpace page, then typed in the name of another, and went to that page… and was stopped cold. There was a vituperative message about her, directed to a co-worker. She went to that person's page, and found an even more vicious reply to the original message.

It was devastating for Schaeffer. "They went back and forth on how much they couldn't stand working with me," she says. "I was absolutely, absolutely horrified. It was very hurtful."

She said nothing to her co-workers, and still hasn't. But in hindsight, Schaeffer has figured out what she should have said to them — and they are words that could stand as a mantra for the modern workplace: "I have a MySpace page, and I know you do too."

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http://www.boston.com/yourlife/articles/2007/05/29/myspace_vs_workplace/